

DELHI | Truant Icons

They may be worshipped on the field, but off it, the demi gods of Indian cricket, read Mahendra Singh Dhoni and Harbhajan Singh, could end up becoming an example no one would want to follow. The UPA Government is all set to crack a whip on awardees skipping national award functions without any reason. The revised guidelines would make it mandatory for the winners of national awards, including the Padma awards, to be present in person to receive the award from the President. In case no valid explanation is offered, the award may be withdrawn. The move comes after both Dhoni and Harbhajan skipped the Padma awards ceremony last week without any prior intimation even though they were in the country at that time. Harbhajan cited a family engagement while Dhoni did not choose to offer an explanation. Sources reveal that if Dhoni still does not offer an explanation, his award may be withdrawn.

The matter was also raised by the home secretary with the sports ministry, which in turn responded on April 17, seeking apt ac-



SINGH AND DHONI

tion. The ministry has also written to the Indian Olympic Association, asking them to warn all awarded athletes that "in the event of a sportsperson not giving prior intimation, the award conferred would stand withdrawn."

by Saurabh Shukla

BANGALORE | Green Halt

When Bangalore Metro officials wanted to chop a few trees in the Lalbagh Botanical Garden to build a station, little did they know that it would invite mass protests. The protesters roped in Lok Sabha candidates Capt. G.R. Gopinath and four-time BJP MP Ananth Kumar for the 'cause'. If this wasn't enough, state Transport Minister R. Ashok asked officials to keep off the trees, citing the Lok Sabha elections and earning himself handy brownie points.

by Stephen David

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